



NESS Heritage

Augmented Reality Guide

State Hermitage Museum и½ Saint Petersburg

User Guide и½ Version 1.4

1. Welcome to NESS Heritage

NESS Heritage is an augmented-reality companion for the State Hermitage Museum in Saint Petersburg, one of the largest and oldest museums in the world, founded in 1764 by Catherine the Great and home to over three million items.

This app turns your phone into a personal guide. Follow a glowing pink line through the halls, scan any artwork to hear its story, plan a route tailored to the time you have and what you love, and join a curated must-see tour of the collection's greatest masterpieces.

This guide explains every feature in detail so you can make the most of your visit.

2. Getting Started

Requirements: a smartphone with a working rear camera and an internet connection. NESS Heritage runs in your browser & no download from an app store is required. For the best experience, allow camera access when prompted and use the app in portrait orientation.

To use NESS Heritage you must first register an account with your email address and sign in. Open the app, tap "Register", enter your email and a password, and confirm the verification code sent to your inbox. After registering once, simply sign in with your email and password on return visits. Your saved scans, photos and itineraries are tied to your account and remain private to you.

On first launch you will be asked for permission to use the camera. This is required for AR Navigation and AR Scan. Your photos are uploaded only when you choose to capture or save a scan; they are never used for anything else without your action.

Tip: A pair of headphones makes the experience more immersive in busy galleries.

3. The Home Screen

The Home screen is your starting point. It introduces the museum and presents four entry points:

🔗 Navigate 🔗 opens the AR navigation view with the pink fluorescent path.

🔗 Scan 🔗 opens the camera to identify and explain any artwork.

🔗 Explore 🔗 browse over 1200 scannable points of interest, filtered by category.

🔗 History 🔗 revisit the artworks you have previously scanned and saved.

Below these, you will find quick links to the Route Planner and the Must-See Guided Tour, plus a selection of featured halls to jump straight into.

4. AR Navigation

Open Navigate to see a live camera view of the gallery in front of you, overlaid with an animated pink fluorescent line that marks the suggested walking path through the museum.

A "Next stop" card at the top tells you the name of the hall you are heading toward and the approximate distance. The bottom panel lists your full route as a series of waypoints; tap any waypoint to set it as your next destination. A checkmark appears for halls you have already passed.

When you arrive at a hall, tap "Scan artwork here" to switch directly into Scan mode and learn about the pieces around you.

Note: The pink path is a camera-overlay guide. It shows the recommended direction and sequence of halls; please also follow the museum's physical signage and floor markings.

5. AR Scan

Scan mode lets you point your camera at any artwork or artifact and receive an instant, expert explanation.

How to scan: align the artwork inside the on-screen frame so the whole piece is visible, then tap the large pink shutter button. NESS captures the image, sends it for analysis, and returns a detailed card with the title, artist, era, hall, a captivating summary, a full explanation, and a surprising fun fact.

If the camera is unavailable, you can upload a photo from your library instead using the "Upload artwork" option.

After a scan you can save it to your History to revisit later, or tap "Scan another" to continue. If NESS cannot recognize the object, it will politely suggest trying a different piece ¹/₂ good lighting and a clear view of the whole work improve recognition.

6. Explore ¹/₂ 1200+ Scannable Points

The Explore screen is a searchable catalog of over 1200 points of interest across the Hermitage, from Renaissance paintings and Scythian gold to monumental decorative vases and the architecture of the halls themselves.

Use the search bar to find works by name, hall, or artist. Use the category chips to filter by Painting, Sculpture, Decorative Art, Antiquity, Treasure, or Architecture. The "Must-see" row at the top highlights the most celebrated pieces in the collection.

Tap any point to jump into Scan mode and learn more about it on the spot.

7. Route Planner

The Route Planner builds a personalized itinerary based on two things: how long you have, and what you are interested in.

Step 1  Choose a duration: Quick (1 hour, ~6 points), Short (2 hours, ~12 points), Half day (4 hours, ~20 points), or Full day (6+ hours, ~35 points).

Step 2  Select your interests: pick one or more categories such as Painting, Sculpture, Decorative Art, Antiquity, Treasure, or Architecture. Leave them all selected to see a balanced mix.

Step 3  Generate: NESS selects the most relevant points, prioritizing must-see masterpieces, and orders them into a sensible walking sequence by floor and hall. You can start the route in AR Navigation, or save it for later.

8. Must-See Guided Tour

The Must-See tour is a curated journey through the 15 greatest masterpieces of the Hermitage, including Leonardo da Vinci's Madonna Litta, Rembrandt's Return of the Prodigal Son, Matisse's The Dance, Malevich's Black Square, the Peacock Clock, and the Scythian Gold Deer.

The tour presents one masterpiece at a time with its image, description, and location. Tap "Next" to advance; a progress bar shows how far through the tour you are. You can pause at any point and resume later.

This tour is ideal for first-time visitors who want to see the undisputed highlights without planning.

9. Scan History

Every scan you save is stored in your History, so you can revisit the artworks you encountered long after you leave the museum.

Each entry shows the captured image, the recognized title, the hall, the era, and the beginning of the explanation. You can delete entries you no longer want. History is private to your account.

10. Tips for a Great Visit

 Start with the Must-See tour if it is your first visit; use the Route Planner for return visits tailored to your interests.

 Galleries are quietest in the late afternoon and on weekdays.

½ The Peacock Clock performs on Thursdays ½ plan accordingly if it is on your route.

½ Hold the phone steady and fill the frame for the best scan recognition.

½ Save battery: close other apps and lower screen brightness in darker galleries.

½ Respect the artworks ½ do not use flash photography.

11. Accessibility & Requirements

NESS Heritage requires a rear camera and internet access. The interface is designed for portrait orientation and is optimized for one-handed use while walking.

If you have reduced mobility, use the Route Planner with a shorter duration and the Architecture category to focus on the grand halls and interiors near the main entrances, which are wheelchair accessible. Elevators connect all floors; ask staff for the accessible route.

The app does not collect personal data beyond your saved scans. You can delete your history at any time.

12. Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Do I need to download an app? A: No ½ NESS Heritage runs in your phone's browser.

Q: Why is the pink line not anchored to the floor? A: The path is an overlay guide showing direction and sequence; please also follow the museum's physical signage.

Q: A scan was not recognized. A: Ensure good lighting and frame the whole piece. You can also upload a photo.

Q: Can I use the app offline? A: An internet connection is required for scan analysis and loading points.

Q: Is my data private? A: Only your saved scans are stored, privately, on your account.

13. About the State Hermitage Museum

Founded in 1764 when Catherine the Great acquired a collection of 225 paintings from a Berlin merchant, the Hermitage grew over decades into one of the world's great museums. Its collections occupy the Winter Palace and four connected buildings along the Neva River.

Today it holds over three million items spanning from prehistory to the present, including the largest collection of paintings in the world. NESS Heritage is an independent experience and is not affiliated with the museum.

14. Support

If you encounter a problem, try reloading the app and re-allowing camera access. For further help, contact the app provider through the channel shared with your invitation.

Thank you for visiting the State Hermitage with NESS Heritage. Enjoy your journey through three centuries of art.